

Mental Health Crisis among Graduates in Pakistan: Coping with Uncertainty in a Competitive World.

Graduation is often seen as a time of celebration as a reward after years of hard work, sleepless nights, and personal sacrifice. Caps are thrown into the air, smiles are plastered across social media and phrases such as "the future is yours" are chanted with gusto. Degrees are framed and photographs are shared and families are in pride. However, for many graduates today, the reality after graduation is very different. Instead of excitement and clarity, an increasing number of young graduates are facing anxiety, depression, emotional burnout, and deep sense of uncertainty for their future.

This silent war has turned into a global mental health crisis in graduates due to economic instability, competitive job markets, rising living costs and social pressure to "succeed" as quickly as possible. Understanding this crisis and learning how to cope with uncertainty is important not only for graduates themselves, but also for their educators, families and policymakers.

The Passage from Student to Graduate: A Vulnerable Time

The transition from student life to professional life is one of the greatest transitions in adulthood. While the university or college offers structure in the form of deadlines, exams and expectations, the post-graduation phase often does not have clear direction.

Graduates are suddenly faced with questions such as:

- What if I don't find a job?
- What if my degree isn't enough?
- What if I bring embarrassment to my family?
- What if I did the wrong thing by changing careers?

This uncertainty may cause severe psychological stress. According to the World Health Organization (WHO), anxiety and depression are among the top mental health problems that have been affecting young adults worldwide

(<https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/mental-disorders>).

Unemployment and Psychological Stress in Graduates

Youth unemployment is one of the gravest problems for the graduates in Pakistan. Each year thousands of students graduate with hopes and ambitions and then come across an unfriendly job

market unable to absorb them. Many graduates apply for dozens sometimes hundreds of positions, and never receive a single interview call. Others accept low-paying, temporary or unpaid positions that have nothing to do with their area of study, just so they don't have to have long gaps in their CVs.

According to the International Labour Organization (ILO), young people in developing economies go through longer, more uncertain and more unstable transitions from education to employment than older workers.

(<https://www.ilo.org/global/topics/youth-employment/lang--en/index.htm>).

This extended period of uncertainty puts graduates in a psychologically fragile position of needing motivation and gradually turning to frustration and a loss of hope.

Repeated rejection takes a toll, emotionally speaking. Every application email or automated rejection email that goes unanswered is a chip away from the self-confidence. Over time, without the practice of being kind to themselves and understanding that they can learn, graduates can begin to internalize failure and believe that they are not capable, skilled, or deserving despite working hard to earn their degrees. Psychologists find that when people look for jobs for a long time, they tend to suffer from higher levels of anxiety, depression, and low self-esteem, especially young adults.

The stress is not only professional but bottled-down deep and personal. In Pakistan, unemployment often means ongoing financial dependence on family members and this can lead to feelings of guilt, shame and being a burden. Graduates may shun social events, family events, or even friends in order to avoid uncomfortable questions about their career progress. This social withdrawal adds more emotional isolation to the picture, and mental health struggles become even more intense.

As the weeks turn into months, unemployment begins to lose its flavour of a passing phase and starts to define a graduate's identity. Confidence wanes, motivation is exhausted and mental fatigue occurs. For many, this is the beginning of chronic anxiety, depression, or burnout providing further evidence of the close relationship between employment difficulties and mental health in the post-graduation phase.

According to the latest Pakistan Bureau of Statistics (PBS) Labour Force Survey 2024-25, the rate of youth unemployment is much higher than the national average with the worst possible situation being seen in provinces such as Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Punjab with youth unemployment rates often reaching 12-15% among young people aged between 15-24 years

(<https://www.pbs.gov.pk/wp-content/uploads/2020/07/LFS-2024-25-Annual-Report.pdf>).

These statistics highlight the fact that even with a degree, young people have significant barriers to accessing the workforce.

There is also a worrying trend in overall unemployment figures. Recent labour force data shows that overall unemployment in Pakistan has risen to about 7.1% from 6.3% in the last five years, and about 8 million people are unemployed in the country (<https://www.aaj.tv/news/30494226/>).

Of this number, particularly a huge proportion, which is estimated at around 4.5 million youth in the age group of 15-24 years old have been unemployed with many of them possessing education degree or technical competence (<https://www.dawnnews.tv/news/1235585>).

These statistics point to a more serious fact: Graduating with a diploma or degree no longer guarantees work, at least in competitive industries where positions are scarce. Moreover, female graduates suffer disproportionately, as youth unemployment among young women is often more common than for young men (<https://www.aiknewshd.tv/2511260018-pakistans-unemployment-hits-71-amid-rising-labour-force>).

This gap between getting a degree and finding steady employment increases uncertainty and makes mental health support and coping mechanisms even more important to young adults in this transition phase.

Cultural Pressure and Expectations from Family

In collectivist cultures such as Pakistan, the success of a graduate is hardly seen as a personal success alone. Instead, it is closely related to family honor, social respect, and financial responsibility. From an early age, young people are taught often indirectly that their education is not only for their own purposes but for the upliftment of the whole family. As a result, graduation is not only the mark of a personal milestone but of the beginning of intense expectations.

This pressure can seriously increase mental distress especially if employment cannot be followed immediately after graduation. Graduates often feel as if they are being silently evaluated not only by their parents, but relatives, neighbors and the community at large.

Many graduates have a constant fear of disappointing parents, especially those who have made financial sacrifices for the education. Even if the parents are supportive, the graduates can feel a sense of guilt, thinking they must be disappointing their families by not becoming a financially independent person soon enough. This guilt for financially dependent can break one's self esteem and cause chronic stress.

Social environment may become emotionally exhausting. Family gatherings, weddings and casual visits are many times accompanied by the same inescapable question: "*Job ka kya bana?*" While the question can be asked in concern, the repeated exposure can cause a deep shame and embarrassment, especially to graduates who are already struggling internally. Over time, many start to avoid social situations altogether, further causing one to become even more isolated and emotionally withdrawn.

In such environments, personal worth is gradually tied only to the status of employment. A graduate who is unemployed may be seen as unsuccessful, irresponsible, or incapable either by others or by himself or herself, regardless of one's skills, effort, or academic achievements. This narrow definition of success does not leave much room for transitional phases, exploration, or delayed time lines.

This experience is supported by research. Studies show that family and societal expectations have a significant impact on increasing the level of stress in young adults of South Asia, especially for educational and career transition

(<https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2020.00329/full>).

The pressure to conform to group expectations can increase anxiety and be a factor in depressive symptoms and an inhibition of people who openly discuss their mental health struggles.

When there is a sense of personal value that is measured mainly in terms of employment and income, there is inevitably a decline in mental health. Graduates can begin to view themselves as failures instead of individuals navigating through a tough economic and social landscape. Without emotional reassurance and realistic expectations from families and society, uncertainty after graduation would be not only a practical problem but a very personal and psychological one.

Social Media: The Comparison Game

Social media plays a powerful role in the development of graduate anxiety, particularly during the uncertain time for graduates after graduation. Platforms such as LinkedIn, Instagram and Facebook have turned into a digital arena where success is always shown and celebrated. Job announcements, promotion posts, acceptance letters, international scholarships, and "new beginnings," updates dotting timelines, given the strong illusion that everyone else does life right.

For the unemployed or struggling graduates, this constant exposure can be emotionally exhausting. Each scroll will be a reminder of what they are yet to do. Even short periods on the social media can make us feel inadequate, self-doubtful, and afraid of falling behind. Over time, graduates can

start comparing themselves to carefully curated online milestones on social media, without considering that social media doesn't generally reflect real life in its entirety.

Coping With Uncertainty: What's Next for Graduates?

Uncertainty can never be eliminated but it can be managed.

1. Accept That Uncertainty Is the Norm fact

One of the most important steps in the protection of mental health after graduation is realizing that uncertainty is not a personal failure, it is a normal part of life transitions. Many graduates have an expectation that once they graduate from their degree, they will know their fate and the path their career will take. When this clarity does not come immediately, they are often quick to attribute the blame to themselves, and start to feel anxious or inadequate.

According to psychologists, uncertainty causes emotional distress due to the lack of a person's sense of control. When things are not clear, the natural reaction of the human mind is worry, overthinking, and fearing the worst. Importantly though, uncertainty does not mean that something has gone wrong. Career paths today are rarely linear and delay is becoming more common in unstable economic conditions.

Mental health experts also underpin that in order to accept uncertainty, people can move from self-blame to self-compassion. Instead of looking at confusion as failure, individuals can begin to look at it as a part of growing. Harvard Health Publishing explains that becoming tolerant of uncertainty makes people more emotionally resilient and better able to deal with stress during difficult phases of their lives.

<https://www.health.harvard.edu/mind-and-mood>

Learning to sit with not knowing also cause of resiliency. Rather than constantly asking the question "What if nothing works out?" graduates are able to move towards more balanced thinking e.g., I have not got all of the answers yet and that's okay. This mindset allows space of psychological freedom to explore options and learn from setbacks in order to adapt without fear of failure.

By embracing the fact that uncertainty is temporary and normal, graduates can take the emotional pressure off of themselves and preserve their sanity. This mindset doesn't remove that there are some challenges in the journey; however, it does not allow uncertainty to harm self-esteem and mental health while in a stage of life that is already demanding.

2. Redefine Success as Based on Your Own Terms

Graduates tend to feel that success is measured by a regular job, high pay or an eminent title. While these markers are traditional markers of achievement, there are others that are measures of progress and personal growth. In the competitive and uncertain job market today it is necessary for graduates to redefine success on their terms. Success can come in many forms and understanding that flexibility can relieve much stress and improve one's mental well-being.

Success may come in the form of gaining experience through internships, short-term projects or entry-level roles. Even if the position is not high paying, every experience builds skills, networks and confidence that will pay off in the long run. A study published in the Journal of Career Development notes the importance of graduates having a focus on skill acquisition and learning opportunities that contribute to higher long-term career satisfaction when compared to those who only focus on immediate salary or title (link.springer.com).

Another significant type of success is that of learning new skills. Whether it is better communication, learning how to code, learning how to use digital tools or building soft skills, continuous learning is a part of personal growth and can make you more employable. Research on lifelong learning has found that people that continue to develop their skills have more confidence and resilience in responding to uncertain job markets (frontiersin.org).

Teaching, freelancing or volunteering are among other ways to build meaningful experience while adding value. For example, volunteering in projects within the community or providing freelance services not just help to strengthen skills, but provide a sense of purpose. Studies show that volunteering and being engaged in something that matters increases life satisfaction, lower symptoms of depression and networks that can lead to future career opportunities (mentalhealth.org.uk).

Finally, preparing for long-term goals constitutes itself as a progress. Not every opportunity will provide immediate rewards, but setting up the framework for an area of desired career aspirations or higher education shows vision, discipline and strategic thinking. Graduates who focus on these steps are more likely to be more successful in the long term than those who only judge themselves on immediate results.

It's important to remember:

Progress is progress even if it's slow progress.

Each little accomplishment, skill learned or experience made is a building block of something larger. In this way, by widening the scope of what it means to achieve success, graduates can keep their self-esteem intact, minimize anxiety, and keep going long after when things are not going so well. Redefining success isn't about lowering the bar, it's about realizing that success can be achieved in a variety of ways, and personal development is just as important a job title as an actual job title.

3. Make Various Structure in Day to Day Life

After graduation the lack of routines can make the days seem aimless and overwhelming. Without the structure that classes, deadlines or schedules provide, many graduates have a difficult time staying productive and motivated. Creating a daily structure even a simple one can help to bring a sense of control and purpose.

Start to set up fixed times for activities that you need to do, such as job finding, skill-building, exercise, learning new tools, etc. Including small breaks, hobbies or social interactions helps to make sure that there is a balance and not burnout. Research has shown that having daily routines, which are consistent and regular, helps to improve mental health, decrease stress and increase focus, especially during times of uncertainty ([Harvard Health Publishing](#)).

Even little things such as writing a to-do list each morning or focusing on professional development for one hour lead to momentum. Over the course of time, this structure leads not only to an increase in productivity but also to strengthen confidence and resilience, which helps the graduates feel that they are going forward despite an unpredictable environment.

4. Talk about It:

Many graduates suffer silently for fear of being judged or disappointing family and friends. But by talking openly about your feelings it could decrease the stress and give you emotional relief. Sharing experiences with trusted friends, mentors or family members helps to establish support networks that help graduates process uncertainty and keep perspectives.

5. Focus on Skill Development

Instead of concentrating only on job outcomes, graduates can find a way to recover a sense of progress through investment in transferable skills such as communication, digital tools, writing or research. Even the little things that are gained in learning new skills, can lead to better confidence, less stress and more opportunities for future employment. Studies done on lifelong learning prove that ongoing skills development enhances resilience and psychological wellbeing ([Frontiers in](#)

[Psychology](#)). Shifting the focus of attention away from fear of failure to the process of personal growth is helpful in helping the graduate feel productive and in control.

6. Upgrade Your Skills for The AI Era and Freelancing.

In today's fast-changing job market, graduates can no longer rely on traditional education or degrees. While you are preparing for interviews and applying to jobs, it is equally important to acquire some online skills that are being in high demand given the changing nature of industries due to artificial intelligence (AI) and automation. Skills like Digital marketing, Graphic design, Content writing, Data analysis, Web development, Artificial intelligence tools management etc are not only useful in conventional employment but they also open up opportunities for freelancing and remote work which is increasingly viable career paths.

Investing time in these skills enables graduates to remain competitive, earn for themselves, and develop a good portfolio even before obtaining a full-time job. For example, a person who knows how to do AI-assisted content creation or graphic design can begin freelancing on websites such as Upwork, Fiverr, or Freelancer and earn some money while gaining real world experience. This dual approach of preparing for traditional employment while learning marketable online skills is a comfort in conditions of uncertain employment.

There is research that supports the importance of continuous skill development. The World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report (2023) draws attention to the fact that people who regularly update their skills in accordance to the new technologies including AI and digital tools tend to have greater career resilience, incomes and adaptability in the face of automation (World Economic Forum). Similarly, there are studies that state that digital skills are becoming more and more linked to employability and success when it comes to freelancing, making them a must-have for graduates in a competitive job market.

Moreover, the online skills that are learned encourage self-directed growth, help to problem solve and create, which are all highly valued by employers or clients alike. By combining traditional preparation for the job with practical online learning, graduates not only improve on job employability, but also open the way for financial independence, flexible working from home, and long-term careers.

Ultimately, the adoption of this strategy ensures that graduates can adapt to the future of work, and become confident of their own abilities instead of passive in a future job market. In a world where

AI is creating a world changing the way work is done quickly, upgrading skills isn't an option, it's a must.

Conclusion

Graduation is a very exciting milestone, but at the same time, it does come with uncertainty, competition, and pressure that can be quite detrimental to mental health. Unemployment, family expectations, social comparison, and the rapid pace of change in technology are all factors that contribute to stress, anxiety and self-doubt. However, graduates can endure this difficult stage through planned strategies.

Accepting uncertainty as part of life and redefining one's own sense of success, structuring daily life, discussing issues openly, seeking professional help, refraining from harmful comparisons, focusing on skill development and upgrading for the AI era are all practical ways to ensure mental health protection amid remaining proactive. Research shows that graduates who employ these coping strategies are less stressed and more resilient and confident about their ability to handle future challenges (World Economic Forum).

Ultimately, success after graduation is not a straight path and one outcome. By being flexible, lifelong learners, and having compassion for yourself, graduates can turn uncertainty into opportunities, be flexible in a rapidly evolving world, and create a fulfilling career for themselves, while also maintaining good mental health.